

23 Salim Ali

Known as the 'Birdman of India', Dr Salim Moizuddin Abdul Ali's (or Dr Salim Ali, as he is better known) name was synonymous with birds.

Salim Ali (1896–1987), born in Bombay and graduated in zoology at St. Xavier's College was an ecologist, scientist, conservationist and pragmatist. A great visionary, he made birds a serious pursuit when it used to be a mere fun for most. Orphaned at a very young age, Salim Ali was brought up by his maternal uncle, Amiruddin Tyabji. Uncle Amiruddin was a keen *shikari* (hunter) and nature-lover. Under his guidance young Salim learnt his first lessons in *shikar* and became aware of the nature around him. He had a deep knowledge and wide-ranging concerns in relation to the natural world. His books *The Book of Indian Birds* and the ten-volume *Handbook of the Birds of India and Pakistan* (Co-authored with S. Dillon Ripley) are the most comprehensive and authoritative guides to more than 1200 species of birds found in the Indian subcontinent. He had a life long passion for birds and immortalised the diminutive bird in his autobiography *The Fall of a Sparrow*.

Salim Ali wanted the conservation of birds and of all the complex interlinked ecological elements constituting their habitat. His belief was 'every form of natural life like plants, animals, insects and birds is a vital cog in the machinery which is natural system of life on this planet.' He was of the opinion that nature's resources should never be depleted, and no one had the right to cause irreversible damage to any species of natural area.

Salim Ali was awarded with many gold medals by various societies and universities.

He passed away in 1987 at the age of 91, after a prolonged battle cancer. But despite all the fame and adulation showered upon him, Dr Ali remained what he was as a nine-year-old—an ever curious person with a passion for birds. The legendary 'birdman' opened up ornithology for

the masses that might otherwise have gone through life seeing fluttering shapes and colours. Because of his single-handed contribution, there is a small group of people bird watching in India today. Dr Ali is no more but his legacy lives on.

Man and Nature in India: The Ecological Balance

It is a matter of some satisfaction to all of us interested in the conservation of Nature that there is now, at last, a growing awareness and interest in India in the preservation of wildlife and wild places.

What is now required is the understanding of the fact that human ecology is an integral part of Nature conservation and all who take a view of life on earth must realise that man's future cannot be considered separately from that of other life.

From the time that man became an agriculturist and husbandman, thereby enabling himself to overcome the natural constraints that had kept the numbers of his predecessor—the hunter and forager—within the environmental capacity, man's impact on his environment has been largely disastrous.

As examples, one could consider the Cradle of Civilisation, West Asia, now largely arid, as a monument to man's misuse of the land. A number of ancient civilisations seem to have culminated in deserts in the same way—Egypt, the kingdoms of West Asia, Carthage and the Indus Valley civilisation.

All seem to have gone to ruin down the same drain. None had profited from the knowledge of earlier disasters. Unhappily, the same sorry process continues today, only that improvements in communications and technology now permit man to exercise his expertise is a creator of deserts on a global scale and at a more accelerated tempo.

As far as forests and wildlife are concerned, there can be hardly any doubt that we in India have been living prodigally off an abundant capital. A study on any endangered natural resource shows that the basic problem in every case is human population, leading to a constant erosion of that resource.

In an article in the *Journal of the Bombay Natural History Society*, M.S. Randhawa provides historical evidence to prove that in the last 2,000 years there has been a progressive desiccation of northern India. As an example, he cites the changes that have occurred in the Mathura region of Uttar Pradesh.

That area, apparently, once received over 2,000 mm of rainfall as against the present 600 mm. The evidence on which Randhawa bases his thesis is mainly the sculptures of the period and specific reference in the Puranas to the Asoka tree (*Saraca asoca*), and other moisture loving plant species, whose present-day distribution is restricted to areas with over 2,000 mm rainfall. Thus, the Mathura region appears to have degraded within historical times from an area capable of supporting luxuriant forests to one with a semi-desert type of vegetation, rather similar to that of the Rajasthan desert.

The loss in the productivity of the land and the consequent degradation of the environment is nowhere more clearly shown than in the history of some of our endangered species of wildlife. The distribution of the Great Indian Rhinoceros sufficiently illustrates this point. This ponderous animal, now restricted to the swampy riverain forests of a few sanctuaries in Assam, West Bengal and Nepal, was found in historic times from Peshawar—where the Moghul Emperor Humayun hunted it—eastward across the Gangetic Plain to Assam.

The fact that the rhinoceros requires a swampy grass jungle to exist is a pointer to the conditions then obtaining in areas which are now practically desert.

The pinheaded duck, another resident of the same swampy forest habitat, became extinct in the thirties of the present century. Loss of its habitat, combined with the fact that it nested on the ground among reeds and not up in tree-holes like our other resident ducks is possibly one of the main reasons for the disappearance of the species.

The distribution of the lion in this country is perhaps further evidence of the result of man-made environmental changes. The widespread extension in the range of the lion—an inhabitant of dry habitats—in North India was possibly correlated with the withdrawal of moist conditions in the Indo-Gangetic Plain. This

was the result of large-scale clearing of the forests as more and more land was brought under cultivation for an ever-increasing human population. The lion itself eventually fell a victim to the rising population pressure, losing its habitat to cultivation.

'Habitat destruction is the primary reason for the disappearance or—rarity of most of our wildlife, and under present conditions there seems every likelihood that the process of destruction will continue.'

It is indeed, a tragic situation. There is not enough land for all the land-hungry and much of the land that is now being cleared under population pressure—some of it magnificent primeval evergreen forest—will surely be abandoned in a permanently ruined state, another martyr to human irresponsibility! It would appear that what is really needed is not more land for cultivation, but better utilization of the land that is already under cultivation.

The disappearance of the rhinoceros, the lion or the tiger are examples striking enough to attract wide attention even of the layman, but there is a considerable invisible loss which, by nature of its obscurity, seldom comes to notice.

One example of such is the loss suffered by the agricultural economy of the country due to the thoughtless destruction of the predators of agricultural pests. And hardly any voice is raised in protest. The reptile skin trade, running into hundreds of tons annually—happily banned at last—effectively removed the snakes and lizards which are amongst the most stringent natural checks on rats and other rodent crop-pests.

Similarly, the trade in frogs' legs removes one of the important Regulators of the populations of harmful insects and other small animals. One observable effect of this commercial exploitation of frogs is the marked increase in land crabs (*Paratelphusa sp.*), which destroy paddy seedlings, and whose numbers were kept in check by the frogs.

Due to superstitious prejudice and ill founded allegations against owls and the diurnal birds of prey, man axes his own legs, as it were. Their senseless destruction deprives agriculture and forestry of the services of some of man's staunchest allies in the ceaseless battle against the fecund tribe of rats, and other scourges like the locust.

In recent years advanced technology has paradoxically enough, added dangerously to the hazards to wildlife and environments by the introduction of chemical pesticides and herbicides in the campaign to grow more food for the burgeoning human population. By the poisonous pollution these have brought about, of water, earth and air, they are boomeranging on man himself.

Whatever conservation measures are now undertaken, or may be undertaken in the future, can be expected to function as no more than stop-gaps, and no permanent remedy for the ecological imbalance can be devised unless and until the human population is effectively contained.

This, then, is the problem. Unless man is able to discipline himself there is no hope of avoiding the ecological disaster towards which he is rapidly heading. In order to restore and regulate the ecological balance, conservation now demands that the human population be drastically controlled, not only for the wise use of the available natural resources but for the very existence of man himself.

To find the remedies one must examine the causes. The evolution of man, unlike that of other animals has, above all, been the evolution of his brain. This is what has enabled him to overcome the limitations natural to other animals. He meets and deals with his environment at two levels: firstly, the intellectual, aided by the vast area of knowledge available to him because of his intellect, and secondly, the physical level in which he is in no way different from other animals.

Man's reproductive capacity lies in the second plane, and to control it, the approach should be through knowledge of the reproductive function of other animals. To this end, fruitful research could be undertaken on the factors that cause seasonal reproductive behaviour in other animals and on whether it would be possible to permanently extend the inhibitory forces.

On the face of it this does not seem an impossible task since, in reverse, we have succeeded in breaking down the seasonal inhibitory force in domestic animals. For instance, the Red jungle Fowl—the ancestor of our domestic poultry—has, unlike the latter, a fixed and limited breeding season in nature. It is a curious fact, but true, that in truly social insects such as ants and bees the majority of

individuals are sterile; thus there is a built-in population control mechanism in the community. Can this model not be emulated by humans?

Whatever method we employ, the intellectual or the physical or a combination of both, time is running out for man. He must realise that his body, like that of other animals, is subject to narrow physical and chemical constraints and that, however intellectually versatile he may be, he could become a victim of ecological disaster just as any other animal if he refuses to pay heed to the warnings of a misused natural system working under fixed natural laws. To us in India especially this is the Writing on the Wall.

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About the Essay

In this essay Salim Ali has discussed importance of human ecology which, is 'an integral part of Nature's conservation'. Man's life cannot be happy unless other insects, plants and animals' lives are ensured. Ali expresses sorrow over man's incapability of not learning from the disasters of the past. The cutting of the forests leads the wildlife to danger and rains are also restricted. The extinction of many species of animals is an indication that human beings will also disappear if man goes on misusing the natural eco-system working under fixed natural laws.

Glossary

arid: of land or climate having little or no rainfall; dry.

prodigally: spending money or resources too freely; extravagant.

ponderous: slow and awkward because of great weight

swampy: (area of) soft wetland, marsh.

herbicide: substance that is poisonous to plants, used to destroy weeds
etc.